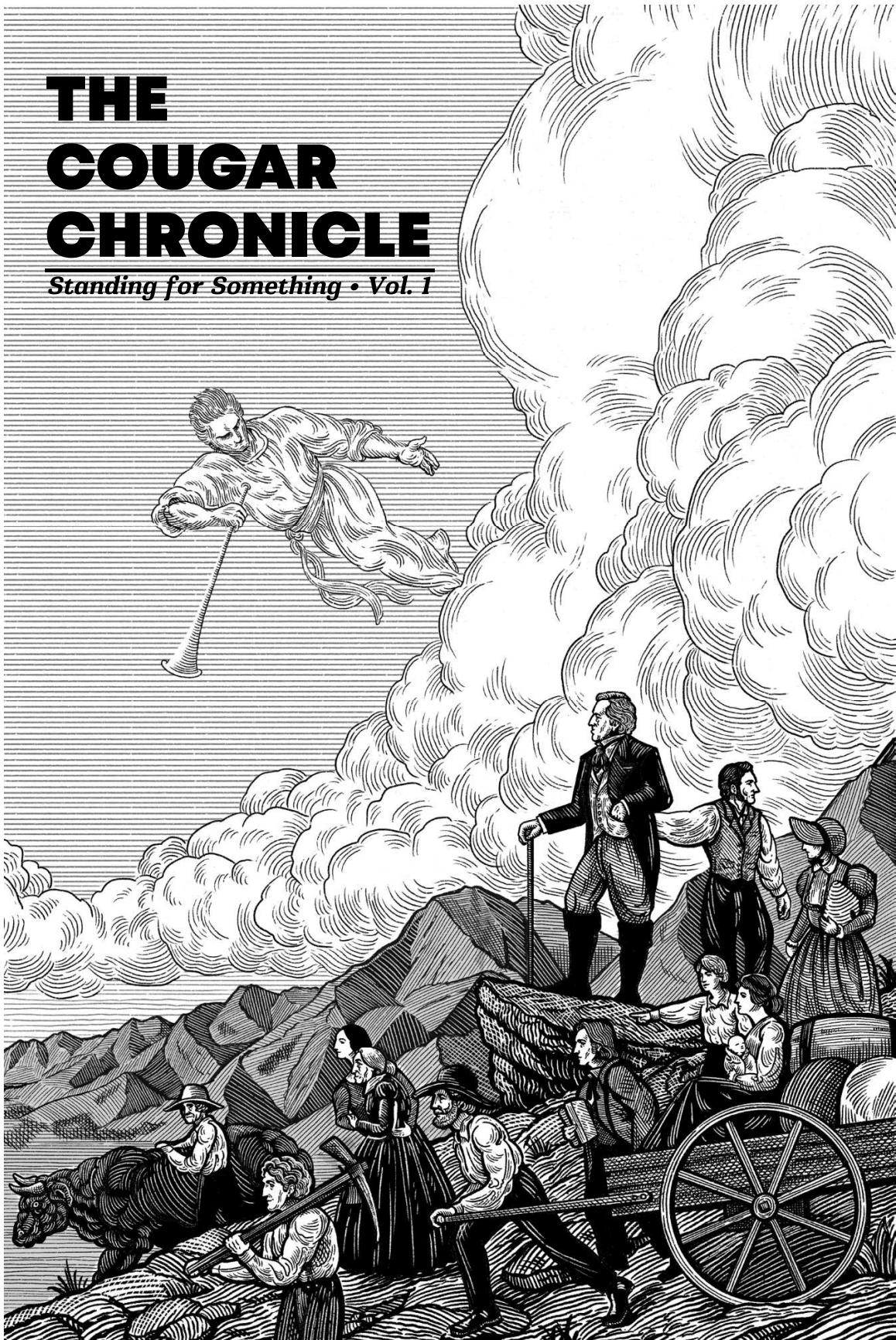


THE COUGAR CHRONICLE

Standing for Something • Vol. 1



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Editor's Note

This inaugural Print Edition is the result of The Cougar Chronicle's gradual, sometimes sudden, evolution over the last few years. It has been on the minds of its editors, past and present, to release a print edition, one that will set the tone and expectation for subsequent releases. At last, it is with excitement that we share this First Edition with our many readers and friends who have supported us from the beginning.

In it you will find a fascinating collection of essays written by students, alumni, guest writers, and a current BYU professor, covering a vast range of themes. Each article topic is of peculiar interest to its author and, as such, is unique in its own way.

The theme, "Standing for Something," is chosen after a book of President Gordon B. Hinckley by the same name. The mission of the Chronicle is to stand for and defend the sacred mission of Brigham Young University—to balance the dual claims of reason and revelation. As we have seen, the trend of American university pedagogy and culture is to abandon altogether the claims of revelation and the responsibility of reason in favor of a secular, godless form of "education."

Co-opted by activists advancing the march of social-justice and enabled by an academic class insistent on the separation between "facts" and "values," our institutions of higher education are underwhelming, to say the least. BYU, however, as manifest in Elder Holland's prophetic "The Second Half of the Second Century of Brigham Young University," is to stand above and distinct from the secular academic world; BYU is to stand for something.

What is BYU to stand for? A search to the beginning of an answer to this question is the purpose of this inaugural Print Edition.

As the Editor, I thank my fellow students, alumni, and guest writers, all of whom are my friends, for their sincere and ongoing effort in the production of this First Edition. Lynn, my father, gave countless hours to format and ensure this print be ready for publication; we give our heartfelt thanks to him. Likewise, our authors have poured hours of study and writing into their articles and I, along with them, am

proud to publish their work for you to read.

As I complete my final semester and now depart from the Chronicle, I express my gratitude for the many supporters, readers, friends, and family members who have and continue to support the work we do. It is from you, the reader, that we find fulfillment and pride in this cause.

We thank the *Intercollegiate Studies Institute* and our generous donors whose ongoing support makes our project possible, and Godwin, an artist of the highest order, for the beautiful and inspiring illustrations. Finally, we thank the many professors at BYU, gems of both spiritual and secular education, who have taught us to stand for something.

We dedicate this inaugural edition to Dr. Ralph Hancock, a man who has helped generations of students stand for Truth. In doing so, we let him lead with the first essay.

JACOB CHRISTENSEN, EDITOR

BYU Mission Alignment and Culture Wars

PROFESSOR RALPH HANCOCK

Ralph Hancock is a Professor of Political Science at BYU, where he teaches the tradition of political philosophy and contemporary political theory. He is the author of “Calvin and the Foundations of Modern Politics” and is the translator of various works, including Pierre Manent’s “Natural Law and Human Rights.” Dr. Hancock’s latest book, “Love and Virtue in a Secular Age,” is scheduled to be published in 2026 by the University of Notre Dame Press

EDITOR’S NOTE: The following article is an unreleased response to BYU-I Professor Jeffrey Thayne’s essay “On Confidence in BYU’s Mission and Potential,” initially published in *Public Square Magazine* in January 2024. In his essay, Thayne urges readers to approach concerns about Brigham Young University with “humility,” cautioning against public criticism of perceived secular or doctrinally misaligned occurrences on campus that may conflict with the university’s gospel-centered mission.

In a recent article, Jeff Thayne argued persuasively against undue alarm concerning BYU’s alignment with its distinctively religious as well as educational mission and counseled against excessive criticism of faculty and administrators at the Provo campus. It is certainly true that any justifiable disappointment and criticism needs to be tempered by appreciation for what the university has contributed to the LDS community and by patience and realistic expectations concerning changes that may be advisable. There is indeed no point in going about with our hair on fire, clamoring to burn the institution down every time another outrage of

the week is reported. It is well to be reminded that BYU is a very big institution, one that is always bound to disappoint various of its constituencies in various ways and one that we can't expect to change overnight. Most encouraging for those of us who indeed would wish for a stronger commitment at BYU to its distinctive educational mission is the obviously heightened emphasis on this mission by Church leaders such as Elders Holland and Gilbert. In addition to these examples of strong and clear counsel, one could cite other speeches by General Authorities (Oaks, Christofferson, Cook) and BYU administrators (President Shane Reese and Academic Vice President Justin Collings) as evidence that concerns about BYU's church mission alignment have been heard and that more accountability to Gospel principles is now being demanded from the highest levels of the University and the Church.

All this counsel is well-founded and well-taken. At the same time, we must beware of the danger opposite to that of alarm, that is, complacency. It is all too easy to underestimate the challenge facing BYU in doing justice to the two sides of its institutional mission, academic and religious. The most inspiring statements of BYU's mission call for an integration of these two missions is a focus on a "gospel methodology" that would apply across units and disciplines of the university. But this, to put it mildly, is much easier said than done, given the intellectual and professional facts on the ground or forces in play. Regarding the empirical studies cited by Thayne showing that BYU is less dominated by leftism than other universities, I will only say that I am neither surprised nor particularly comforted by such data. It is true that we are not as far gone as many institutions, but that is a rather low standard of evaluation: not many institutions have our mission and our source of support. Obviously, BYU is much less "liberal" or leftist or progressive or woke than the vast majority of academic institutions, but what counts as "liberal" or "conservative" is always relative to a prevailing spectrum of opinion, which can hardly be our final standard for determining fundamental principles that should animate teaching and research at BYU. It seems plausible that mainstream opinion at BYU generally lags a decade or two behind national

academic opinion in its leftward drift, but I don't see this as a great cause for celebration.

Much depends on how we diagnose BYU's illness and, thus, on what we think it would mean for it to be healthy. It is tempting and somewhat comforting to assume that the main problem at BYU is indicated by the outrage of the week: a Family Life teacher clearly undermining the Family Proclamation, an invited professor touting "iniquity" in the Book of Mormon as "inequity," a sociology professor assigning students to go seek out examples of the sin of "whiteness," or, more recently, a "therapist" enthusiastic about masturbation scheduled as a sponsored speaker by an official BYU student organization. Such outrages are far from trivial, of course, but suppressing them is a relatively realistic goal. Patently ideological agendas can be suppressed; a few really bad actors can be incentivized to keep their Woke radicalism to themselves or, in a few cases, to pursue their careers elsewhere. Probably under BYU's new regime, we can expect spectacular offenses against faithful LDS sensibilities to be significantly reduced. But what if such flagrant ideological performances are the tip of an iceberg of dominant opinion among some critical mass of BYU faculty?

It is tempting to avoid questions of "dominant opinion" in addressing the question of BYU's mission alignment. BYU is an institution of higher education that is distinctive in its commitment to educating the student as a whole person as understood in the light of the Restored Gospel. At least since Pres. Kimball's much-quoted "Second Century" address at BYU, we have been exhorted repeatedly to strive to be "bilingual," speaking both the language of scholarship and that of faith.

But, of course, this attractive formula of "bilingualism" assumes that these two languages are fundamentally compatible. Certainly, they should be: if scholarship and the gospel are both about truth, then these two approaches to the truth must ultimately be friends. But are our scholarly disciplines based firmly on the pursuit of truth? Anyone who pays attention to higher education in America well understood, even before the example of Claudine Gay at Harvard advertised the fact, that American universities have

massively turned their attention and their resources to supporting what are considered “progressive” political causes, nicely distilled in the acronym DEI: “diversity,” “equity,” and “inclusion” (Yes, I insist on the “square quotes” in all three cases). This activism is now what passes for or has simply replaced the pursuit of truth. But even if we set aside the pervasive influence of this ideologically activist model of higher education, we see that the disciplines are hopelessly fragmented and specialized in a way that all but effaces any recognizable pursuit of a “truth” relevant to us as human beings – as saints and as citizens, let’s say – rather than, for example, as technicians of human behavior or social movements or arcanelly subversive approaches to the humanities.

Already in 1988, in what is perhaps the boldest address by a BYU President to university employees and the most well-informed concerning the nature of the institutional obstacles the university faces in integrating faithful and intellectual approaches to the truth, Jeffrey R. Holland referred to “the perpetuation of dividedness, departmentalization, specialties, subspecialties, and subspecies of subspecialties” that has driven all “the great human questions ... [to] the bottom of an academic dumpster...” No one is getting paid to attend to what should be the university’s central (though, of course, not only) mission: “to love the truth and gather it, [and] to organize and integrate it as well.” No one is hired or incentivized to ask what might be meant by an “even-balanced soul.” Those with an interest in “general education” are left to cobble together some “interdisciplinary” conversation, which cannot be a very promising project as long as all the concerned disciplines more or less explicitly repudiate the very notion of a well-ordered soul as essential to the pursuit of an integral and humanly meaningful “truth.” Our efforts towards “bilingualism” are doomed by the fact that, as academics, we speak a thousand different languages that share nothing but indifference or, in more interesting cases, open hostility to the very idea, the classical and Christian idea, of a “soul.”

In sum, What if our two languages, those of “faith” and “scholarship,” are (owing to fundamental developments in moral “culture” or “worldview”) increasingly incompatible? And as we aspire

to ever greater professional influence and prestige, who do we think is training and determining the dominant tongue of the faculty we are now hiring, or, for that matter, the faculty we have been hiring for decades, at least? Who is setting the standards for prestigious research and publication by which we hire, promote, and reward faculty?

What if the myriad languages of the contemporary academy formally exclude any translation into a gospel vocabulary concerned with ultimate human purposes and the permanent features of the human condition? The days of a more or less comfortable “bilingualism” within the paradigms of academically dominant disciplines may well be gone. Any shared language that might result from an ongoing truce or compromise between the gospel and this academy will, in the long run, be a fool’s bargain for the religious junior partner, who will be left with a very impoverished vocabulary from a human and spiritual point of view, from which to draw.

To put the matter plainly: the contemporary academic enterprise (and this goes back decades at least) is, depending upon the discipline or subdiscipline, either clearly leftist (“progressive” when not “woke”) in its fundamental orientation or, it strives for scientific neutrality by refusing to address fundamental moral and philosophical questions, thus rendering itself vulnerable to the default setting of academic and other elites – that is, a leftist (broadly liberationist-egalitarian) setting. (Many of my more academically savvy readers, who may unhappily have read this far, will now be asking: what could possibly be wrong, morally and religiously, with the adoption of personal freedom and social equality as ultimate goals? You make my point.)

Inevitably, my attempt to assess the challenges facing BYU has led me onto political and ideological territory. I find myself (and not for the first time) open to the charge that I am fanning the flames of a “culture war.” It is common now to establish one’s good sense and moderation by deriding the term and the sensibility of the “culture warrior.” Who would want to be seen as tilting at the windmills of an imaginary conflict while serious people are calmly diagnosing circumscribed problems and recommending practical

solutions attractive to all people of goodwill? But what exactly is the argument against the language of “culture war”? That there is no such thing among us as a fundamental social and political division that turns on fundamental moral and religious questions? Or that there may once have been, when now old folks were young, such a division, a war, but that it’s over, “been there, done that” – over, no doubt, I suppose, because we’ve lost? That some who use the term are sometimes inarticulate in identifying what’s at stake and unrealistic in their cultural and political expectations? This last may certainly be conceded, but this concession does nothing to dispose of the more fundamental question: is our society divided? Over something(s) fundamental? Does what is at stake concern, or does it not concern, our religion? Our fundamental moral orientation? Our religious university? It is comforting to assume that the fundamental conflicts, the moral-political plate tectonics roiling our society, have little or nothing to do with how we understand what it means to follow Christ on the one hand or how we understand “scholarship” on the other. But in fact, the fundamental division at work in the world goes to the heart of both the life of faith and the rational pursuit of truth.

But dismissive language regarding a “culture war” does little to clarify what is at stake concerning BYU, its mission, or the dominant ideological orientation of its faculty. James Davison Hunter, who contributed most to the currency of the term “culture war,” saw rightly that the fundamental question in it concerns the standing of moral truth. Is there an abiding moral truth, or is moral truth a matter of social construction and “progressive” unfolding? Of course, an intelligent person can give due consideration to each of these poles of opinion and see some reason on both sides, but the question of fundamental orientation remains an important one, not only for individuals but for society, law, and politics. So anyone is free to propose another name for the basic question and the basic conflict, but these remain real, and dismissal of “culture wars” does nothing to clarify the matter. In fact, the derision of “culture warriors” has become a wearisome weapon of, yes, the culture warriors on the now winning, “progressive” side. We play into the hands

of the dominant, secular-progressive culture when we deride our friends for taking up the fight against the ruling worldview.

Prof. Thayne, in fact, helpfully limns what is at stake in the culture wars by identifying the problem of the growing dominance of “expressive individualism.” And in so doing, he takes a side – the right side, I dare say. *But it is a side.* And it’s a side in a polarity that, while it does not exactly map partisan political divisions in the United States, is far from unrelated to them. Prof. Thayne’s position is, happily, a conservative position. Would it please him if we spoke of “worldview wars” rather than “culture wars”? Whatever term we use, the conflict is there, and it is all-too-relevant at once to (1) the very way we understand our Christianity, (2) our most fundamental political divisions, and (3) the question of dominant opinion at BYU.

To be sure, BYU has an interest in keeping a low political profile, and the Church even more so. I am not arguing that we should deliberately position ourselves as part of a political movement or brandish the term “conservative” (a term whose meaning now is, to say the least, unstable). But striving at every turn to dissociate ourselves from anything that might smell “conservative,” much less “right-wing,” to the reigning arbiters of correct (or “moderate” or “neutral”) opinion is a fool’s errand.

I would not claim to give any snapshot of the current distribution of opinion on such a fundamental question among BYU faculty. No doubt many, perhaps most, would rather not be pressed at all on such a question. But pressed, I am willing to predict we will be. The question is not so much the current distribution of opinion or ideological orientation among BYU faculty. The question concerns rather the social plate tectonics that underly the whole academic enterprise. On the basis of a sensitivity to the most fundamental forces at work in society, I would expect a massive drift of BYU personnel towards ever more solidarity with the larger, “mainstream” secular intellectual and academic world to continue even accelerate – unless some equally massive change in incentive structure (which goes well beyond the most inspiring exhortation) is introduced into the institution.

The broadly left-progressive drift of BYU faculty can hardly be surprising if we step back and take a large view of BYU's place in the overall picture of American and Western education in light of the broadest social, political, and economic forces. BYU sees itself as grooming elite professionals to fill their roles in a global society of technology, commerce, and expertise. This is not in itself objectionable; this is what universities do. But the elite global class to whom our students – and, first of all, our faculty – aspire is not a neutral force, morally and politically. We are seeing Western societies divide increasingly between “anywheres” (global technical elites) and “somewheres” (people attached both economically and affectively to their countries and communities). Naturally, BYU aspires to be part of the global elite and to train students to be among the best and the brightest. But this elite tends to be as detached from traditional morality and religion as it is from country and family. To educate our students to be part of this elite is to accept the moral and intellectual formatting that necessarily accompanies membership in this international class. This formatting is essentially liberal-progressive and, of late, increasingly “woke,” touting engineered “diversity,” radical feminism & unlimited abortion, etc.

Of course, both of us are well acquainted from long experience with the social milieus of higher education and, more generally, with the leadership class in Western societies. Along with many others, we have navigated a path attempting to interact positively with mainstream elites while remaining true to our deepest convictions. We have practiced the “bilingualism” that Pres. Kimball recommended in 1975. There was nothing nefarious in this navigation. But as the global elite solidifies its ruling status and abandons moderating limitations on its ambitions, the navigation becomes more difficult, and eventually impossible. This seems to me to describe BYU's present or emerging situation. The two languages are diverging at an accelerating pace, and one is less and less translatable into the other. This presents a wrenching challenge to BYU, one that I think we can no longer defer without abandoning our fundamental loyalties.

Prof. Thayne has mentioned the need to avoid political contro-

versy. Of course, we need to stay above the fray of electoral politics, and we must always strive to increase the proportion of light to heat in our discussions. But neither the moral-political dimension of elite socialization nor that of our distinctive religious-educational mission will go away, however much we might want to avoid the conflict between them. The moral opinions and global ruling ambitions of the ascendant social class are connected with a vision of humanity that is simply incompatible with any serious understanding of the gospel. Global development is of a piece with rights of sexual liberation, abortion rights, and transgenderism, for example. It is becoming impossible to aspire to membership in this class without embracing or at least deferring to these opinions. To avoid the questions that are derisively dismissed as pertaining to a futile “culture war” is simply to ratify the victory of the established elites in this culture war. Naturally, those who think they have practically won are eager to convince us of the vanity of any further contestation.

For those candidates for elite recruitment who see themselves as religious, the worldview of a morally liberated and global (post-political) humanity offers itself in the form of a counter-religion. Christianity – very much including the Restoration, alas – is invited to reinterpret itself in terms of the elite vision of secular global progress. This vision is already the default setting of the educated class, not to mention PhDs. At BYU, there is a very prevalent tendency for all prophetic counsel to be filtered through this lens. While we can still benefit from skill in navigating different worlds, a stop-gap “bilingualism” will no longer suffice to keep peace with the academic mainstream.

I’ve been reading a remarkable book by Joseph Bottum: *An Anxious Age*. He describes how the Protestant elite became the Progressive elite and how a religious quest for purity and salvation was transformed into a secular agenda. I have to say that Bottum’s description is palpably recognizable in the now ascendant LDS professional sensibility; it is a massive presence, even, alas, the very air we breathe. Here is an excerpt:

“This is the final remnant of the Christianity of their ancestors,

the last enduring bit of their inheritance: a social gospel, without the gospel. For all of them, the sole proof of redemption is the holding of a proper sense of social ills. The only available confidence about their salvation, as something superadded to experience, is the self-esteem that comes with *feeling* that they oppose the social evils of bigotry and power and the groupthink of the mob.

Up in its thin air, such a social ethics touches only lightly on personal morality, and it does not reach down at all to the old, earthy stuff of life and death that religion once took as its deep concern. And that is precisely the problem.”

A suspicion of the alleged narrowness of traditional religion and a feeling of superiority to our religious tradition has become the very stuff of a new academic religion. The BYU community is all too eager to enjoy the symbolic and material rewards of membership in this new religion of the global elites. The self-esteem of those engaged in the academic enterprise is increasingly based on a feeling of superiority to those who remain attached to old teachings and old commandments. All counsel from Church and university leadership tends to be filtered from the standpoint of this supposed ethical and intellectual superiority.

I do not see how these strong tendencies to a new humanistic religion, deeply abetted as they are by broad economic and social forces in the contemporary world, can be countered without clearly naming them and warning against them. And I do not see how it will be possible to name and counter these forces without our being perceived to be in alliance with politically charged counter-tendencies in our society and in our polity. I see no way to counter this tendency that will not be labeled “political” and “conservative” by those who have a stake in membership in the secular elite. As Elder Christofferson said, we must never be contentious in spirit, but we cannot avoid contending for truth and against falsehood.

Is “gospel methodology” at BYU to be a serious religious-intellectual project? If so, we will by no means avoid intellectual and public conflict with the powers that be. This is why Pres. Kimball told us that “in its second century, BYU must become the last remaining bastion of resistance to the invading ideologies.” So,

do we recognize invading ideologies or not? Do we oppose them? Whether we like it or not, we are at war with powers and principalities. We must not relish a militant, unreasoned, and unreasonable posture. But neither must we concede the whole territory of fundamental assumptions to the secular mainstream.

Should we relax, therefore, and trust calmly in BYU's institutional soundness, as Prof. Thayne urges? Certain it is that we cannot expect such a big institution to turn on a dime. But shall we then just take a deep breath and squelch our indignation when we learn of yet another example of a secular-progressive-expressive- BYU professor proffering their wares with administrative support at our church institution? I will not try to prescribe just the right tone or vocabulary that ought to be used in addressing specific cases of ideological agendas incompatible with any serious commitment to the Church and the Gospel at BYU. Jeff has proposed Elder Maxwell as an example of a "bridge-building" and "non-adversarial" approach. I conclude, then, with this example of bridge-building from a BYU Devotional by the non-adversarial Elder Maxwell, October 10, 1978:

Your discipleship may see the time come when religious convictions are heavily discounted. M. J. Sobran also observed, "A religious conviction is now a second-class conviction, expected to step deferentially to the back of the secular bus, and not to get uppity about it." *This new irreligious imperialism seeks to disallow certain of people's opinions simply because those opinions grow out of religious convictions. Resistance to abortion will soon be seen as primitive. Concern over the institution of the family will be viewed as untrendy and unenlightened.*

In its mildest form, irreligion will merely be condescending toward those who hold to traditional Judeo-Christian values. *In its more harsh forms, as is always the case with those whose dogmatism is blinding, the secular church will do what it can to reduce the influence of those who still worry*

over standards such as those in the Ten Commandments.

It is always such an easy step from dogmatism to unfair play—especially so when the dogmatists believe themselves to be dealing with primitive people who do not know what is best for them. It is the secular bureaucrat's burden, you see.

(my emphasis – rch)

